THE MAN WHO ERASED HIMSELF

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A Narrative Research Document on the "Peter Bergmann" / Sligo Man Case

Prepared for: the scriptwriter.

Purpose: a structured, fully cited factual narrative to be adapted into a video essay script for YouTube.

Status of case: unidentified as of September 2026 — seventeen years and three months.

HOW TO USE THIS DOCUMENT

On the name.

The man called himself Peter Bergmann. It was not his name. I use "Peter Bergmann" in quotation marks on first appearance, Bergmann as shorthand through the middle sections, then finally shifting deliberately to Sligo Man in Section VIII. The shift is not cosmetic — it marks the point where the story stops being about the identity he performed and starts being about the one we failed to find.

On sourcing tiers.

Citations are marked by reliability:

- **(T1)** — Primary journalism, official Garda releases, court/inquest record. Cite freely.
- **(T2)** — reputable secondary and international press, trade and festival documentation. Cite with attribution.
- **(T3)** — flagged in Appendix D. Do not put on screen as fact without independent verification.

On citation style.

References follow APA 7th edition. In-text citations are author–date; publication names appear in the reference list rather than in the body. Where a work has no named author, the citation uses a shortened title. Two Boland 2019 works are distinguished as 2019a (the podcast) and 2019b (the article), ordered by title as APA requires.

On the contradictions.

The public record genuinely conflicts on several points. Those conflicts have been pulled out of the narrative and collected in *Appendix D*.

I. THE IRISH GOODBYE

(Not sourced material — this is my own framing device, it makes the viewer complicit before it makes them a spectator.)

Have you ever been at a party or event only to feel the sudden urge to disappear without a trace? Maybe it's been a long night, and you're ready to go home — the energy it would take to say goodbye to everyone doesn't seem worth it. By the time you reached the bride and groom, you'd be doing everyone a disservice by staying any longer. You made your appearance. They've seen you. What's one more "congratulations," anyway? So you slip behind the crowd, open the back door, and vanish without anyone noticing you've gone.

If you've ever acted on that impulse, congratulations — you've pulled off what's known as the Irish Goodbye. According to *Quartz*, the linguist Anatoly Liberman traces the saying back to the British "French leave," first recorded in 1751, to which the French replied in kind with *filer à l'anglaise* — "to leave the English way" ("Is it the Irish goodbye," n.d.; see also "What is an Irish goodbye," 2025; "Why is sneakily leaving," 2023) **(T2)**. Playful as it is, nearly every nation has its own version of this vanishing act, and at some point it washed ashore in Ireland and stayed.

We've all thought about disappearing, for our own sake and for the sake of everyone around us. But however you've pulled off your own covert exit, chances are someone still saw you. A passerby caught the door swinging open out of the corner of their eye. A stranger glanced up as you climbed into your car. Cameras followed you all the way to your doorstep. It is nearly impossible to slip past every set of eyes in your path on any given night.

So how did one man slip past *everyone* — only to turn up dead on a beach in a village in northwest Ireland?

II. THE BODY

Tuesday, 16 June 2009. Just after six in the morning at Rosses Point, County Sligo.

Arthur Kinsella had driven his son Brian out to the beach so Brian could train — he was preparing for a local Sligo triathlon. Near the slipway, at the stretch of shoreline known locally as Deadman's Point, they found a man lying face down at the water's edge (Boland, 2019b) **(T1)**.

Kinsella later described the body as marble cold. No footprints were to be seen in the sand around it. His guess was that the man was around sixty-five (Boland, 2019b) **(T1)**.

Kinsella called Sligo Garda Station. Sergeant Terry MacMahon came out with a tarp to cover the body. Dr Valerie McGowan pronounced the man dead at eight o'clock (Boland, 2019b) **(T1)**.

What Sgt. MacMahon noticed first was the clothing — more specifically the arrangement of the clothing. The man was wearing a navy t-shirt tucked into pink-and-purple striped swimming trunks, with a pair of navy underpants pulled on over the top. A waterproof quartz watch on his left wrist. And on a rock nearby, a pile of clothes folded with care: a black leather jacket, navy chino trousers, a black sleeveless jumper, dark socks, and black leather shoes (An Garda Síochána, 2021; Boland, 2019b) **(T1)**.

Every label had been cut out of every garment (Boland, 2019b) **(T1)**.

There was no wallet.

No passport.

No credit card.

No phone.

No keys.

Nothing at all that carried a name.

The case was logged that morning under the only description available to them: an unidentified male on Rosses Point beach.

III. THE FOOTAGE

Everything that follows was reconstructed after the fact, and almost all of it was reconstructed from CCTV. Filmmaker Ciaran Cassidy, who later made a documentary about the case, worked through roughly thirty-two hours of footage. The Gardaí worked through more (Points North Institute, n.d.; Short of the Week, 2015) **(T2)**.

Friday, 12 June

He appears on camera at the Ulsterbus depot on Foyle Street in Derry, sometime between roughly half past two and four in the afternoon. At four o'clock he boards the bus for Sligo — a two hour and twenty-eight minute journey (Locate International, 2023) **(T1/T2)**.

How he reached Derry has never been established. His name appears on no passenger manifest for any flight or sailing. At the time, foot passengers arriving by ferry from Britain faced no identity checks. The investigation was never able to place him anywhere in the world before that bus depot (Boland, 2019b; IrishCentral, n.d.-a) **(T1/T2)**.

He steps off in Sligo at 6:28 p.m. carrying a black duffel bag and a black shoulder bag. He takes a taxi to the Crúiscín Lán guest house on Connolly Street. It's at capacity — June's at the height of the tourist season, doesn't help that it's a Friday on top of that. He goes on to the Sligo City Hotel on Quay Street. Hotel CCTV records him walking in at 6:52 p.m. (Boland, 2019b; Garcia, 2019) **(T1)**.

At the desk he writes his name — Peter Bergmann — and an address: Ainstettersn 15, 4472 Wien. He pays cash, sixty-five euros a night for three nights. He is given room 705. At no point is he asked for any form of identification (Boland, 2019b; Garcia, 2019) **(T1)**.

The name he wrote down was not his own.

The address he wrote down does not exist.

There is no such street in Vienna. In fact, Vienna's postcodes only run from 1000 to 1901 — 4472 is the postcode for Blackall and Mount Enniskillen in Queensland, Australia.

Saturday, 13 June

At around 10:49 a.m. he walks into the General Post Office in Sligo and buys stamps — eighty-two cent stamps, the international rate — and airmail stickers (Boland, 2019b; "Peter Bergmann: Renewed appeal," 2023) **(T1)**. *(Sources conflict on whether he bought eight or ten. See Appendix D.)*

Whether he ever posted anything was never established. See Section V.

A member of staff entered his hotel room. She claims he reacted as if caught doing something he shouldn't have been, but was ultimately relieved to see it was a member of staff (Short of the Week, 2015) **(T2)**.

Then a pattern becomes evident.

Over the three days he stays at the hotel, CCTV records him leaving thirteen separate times, each time carrying a purple plastic bag, visibly full. Upon each return to the hotel, the bag is completely empty (Boland, 2019b) **(T1)**.

Not once — not on a single one of those thirteen trips — is he ever filmed putting anything down, throwing anything away, or handing anything to anyone. Detective Inspector John O'Reilly, who oversaw the case, confirmed that no footage ever captured the bag being emptied (Boland, 2019b) **(T1)**.

Nothing he disposed of has ever been recovered.

Sunday, 14 June

Late that morning, around eleven, he gets into a taxi driven by Gerard Higgins and asks to be taken toward Rosses Point. When they arrive he does not get out. He does not swim. He asks to be driven back to the bus station. He pays with a crisp twenty-euro note.

Higgins remembered one thing distinctly about the man: a single gold tooth in the back of his mouth (Boland, 2019b) **(T1)**.

He ends the day with more trips with the purple bag. More returns with it empty.

Monday, 15 June

He asks for a late checkout and is given until one o'clock. He hands in his key at around 1:05 p.m., wearing a pale blue long-sleeved shirt, a black tank top, dark trousers and a black leather jacket. He carries the duffel bag, the shoulder bag and the purple bag (Boland, 2019b; Locate International, 2023) **(T1/T2)**.

He does not take a taxi. He walks — down Quay Street, along Wine Street — and at one point stops in the doorway of the Quayside Shopping Centre and simply stands there for a moment. Garcia, who traced the route on foot, described him as poised like a man about to turn back (Garcia, 2019) **(T1)**.

He does not.

At 1:32 p.m. he is on camera at the bus station. The black duffel bag is gone. Nobody knows where it is.

At the station café he buys a cappuccino and a toasted ham and cheese sandwich. He sits beside a woman and does not speak to her. He takes scraps of paper from his pocket, reads them, writes something, then tears them up and drops them in a bin (Boland, 2019b; Garcia, 2019) **(T1)**.

He asks the depot inspector, Vincent Dunbar, which bay the Rosses Point bus leaves from. Dunbar later said the man looked like someone on business — stressed, in pain, not entirely himself (Boland, 2019b) **(T1)**.

He buys a single ticket. No return (Boland, 2019b) **(T1)**.

The bus departs in the early afternoon. *(Sources give 2:20 p.m. and 2:40 p.m. — see Appendix D.)* He gets off at the Yeats Country Hotel stop at around three o'clock.

Monday evening, Rosses Point

For the next nine hours he is seen repeatedly. Sixteen witnesses in total (Boland, 2019b; Garcia, 2019) **(T1)**.

The timeline of his last known sightings is as follows:

- *4:00 p.m.* — walking with the black bag over his shoulder.
- *5:00 p.m.* — near the yacht club.
- *9:10 p.m.* — seen by two women, they note his professional appearance stating, he looked both out of place and out of time (Short of the Week, 2015) **(T2)**.
- *9:30 p.m.* — seen by Dermot and Paula Lahiff, a couple who had come out to watch the sunset. They described him moving slowly along the shore, trousers rolled up, walking right to left in a way that struck them as almost ritual. (Boland, 2019b) **(T1)**.
- *10:30 p.m.* — carrying a plastic bag, wearing glasses.
- *11:00 p.m.* — still on the beach.
- *11:10 p.m.* — sitting on a bench.
- *11:50 p.m.* — the last confirmed sighting. Carrying a plastic bag, walking at the water's edge.

High tide was at approximately 12:25 a.m. (Boland, 2019b) **(T1)**.

He greeted people. Several witnesses recalled that he said hello.

IV. THE AUTOPSY

The post-mortem examination was carried out on 17 June 2009 at Sligo University Hospital by the consultant pathologist Dr Clive Kilgallen (Boland, 2019a, 2019b) **(T1)**.

He was dying. He had advanced prostate cancer that had already metastasised — into bone, into his chest, into his lungs. On the medical evidence he had, at most, weeks left (Boland, 2019b) **(T1)**.

His heart was already damaged. The examination found ischaemic heart disease and evidence of previous heart attacks (Boland, 2019b) **(T1)**.

He had only one kidney (Boland, 2019b) **(T1)**.

He had extensive dental work, including the gold tooth the taxi driver remembered — upper back right, exactly where Higgins said he had glimpsed it (Boland, 2019b) **(T1)**.

He did not drown. Kilgallen found none of the classical signs of salt-water drowning. The cause of death was acute cardiac arrest — his heart stopped, at or near the moment he entered the water (Boland, 2019b) **(T1)**. *(The inquest in April 2010 nevertheless recorded a verdict of death by drowning. This discrepancy is real and unresolved — see Appendix D.)*

And there were no drugs in his system at all. No painkillers. No sedatives. Nothing (Boland, 2019b; Murphy, 2025) **(T1)**.

A man with metastatic cancer through his bones had been walking a beach for nine hours, greeting strangers, with a single packet of aspirin in his pocket (An Garda Síochána, 2021) **(T1)**.

What he was carrying, and what it said

The Gardaí had almost no man to work with, so they worked the objects instead.

On or near the body:

- Black leather shoes, size 44, made by Finn Comfort — a German manufacturer — in 2002.
- A black leather jacket and navy chino trousers, both C&A, a chain that at the time had no Irish outlets but was ubiquitous in Germany and Austria.
- A black sleeveless Tommy Hilfiger jumper.
- A black leather belt branded "Key West USA," made in Italy.
- Aspirin manufactured by Bayer in the Czech Republic and distributed in Germany.
- Hansaplast plasters — a German brand.
- An envelope containing one hundred forty euros in notes and nine euros in coins.
- Tissues.
- An unopened bar of soap labelled "Mild Soap, Hotel Care" — stocked by no hotel in Ireland.

(An Garda Síochána, 2021; Locate International, 2023; Murphy, 2025) **(T1/T2)**

Everything the man had on him pointed in one direction: German-speaking central Europe. His accent, which every witness who spoke to him described as heavily German. His shoes, his coat, his trousers, his painkillers, his plasters. And a bar of soap from a hotel that was not in Ireland.

Never found:

His glasses. The stamps. The blue shirt. The black shoulder bag. The purple bag. Any form of identification whatsoever.

V. THE SEARCH

The investigation ran for five months. At its peak, ten officers were assigned to it. Over the years the file passed through three successive detective inspectors (Garcia, 2019) **(T1)**.

Detective Inspector John O'Reilly oversaw it in 2009; he was later promoted to Chief Superintendent in the Cavan-Monaghan division. Detective Inspector Ray Mulderrig held the file by 2019 — the third DI to do so (Boland, 2019b; Garcia, 2019) **(T1)**.

They ruled out foul play early. What they could not rule out was intent. Mulderrig characterised it as a deliberate act by someone who knew exactly what they were doing (Garcia, 2019) **(T1)**. Sergeant MacMahon, the first officer at the scene, went further, and wondered aloud whether the man's ability to move through a town full of cameras without ever being caught discarding anything suggested specialized training of some kind — military or police (Boland, 2019b) **(T1)**.

Mulderrig also posed the question the investigation could never answer: why Sligo? If a man wanted somewhere beautiful and quiet to die, the west coast of Ireland and Scotland offered him a hundred choices. Something brought him to this town in particular, and nobody has ever been able to say what **(T3 — widely attributed to Mulderrig via secondary press; verify wording against Boland, 2019b, before quoting on screen)**.

The stamps that led nowhere

The single most promising lead was the post office. He had bought international stamps and airmail stickers. If he had posted letters, those letters went somewhere, and somewhere there was a recipient.

The post office had CCTV covering the interior post boxes. When the Gardaí went to retrieve it, the footage had not been saved to the drive — O'Reilly described a technological failure that meant the file simply was not there. The exterior post boxes had no cameras at all (Boland, 2019b) **(T1)**.

O'Reilly's conclusion was blunt: they could not say with any certainty that he had posted anything at all (Boland, 2019b) **(T1)**.

No letter has ever surfaced.

Have you seen this man?

At this point in the investigation, it evolves from a local mystery to an inquiry of international scale. In 2015, the French newspaper *Le Monde* published an investigation by Julien Guintard. Guintard contacted the Austrian police directly — the authority whose jurisdiction the man's fabricated address supposedly fell within. The Austrians told him they had never been contacted by the Irish police. Guintard also reported that there was no Interpol entry for the man in either the missing-persons or the wanted-persons category (Guintard, 2015) **(T1)**.

A man in German shoes, carrying German-distributed aspirin, speaking with a German accent, had died in Ireland — yet it took six years for the investigation to finally leave the island and catch Europe's attention.

Attempts were made. Boland reported that appeals eventually ran in an Austrian and then a German newspaper, with no result. A forensic-art specialist based in Germany produced facial images in the hope of jogging a memory; they jogged nothing (except a nightmare or two). And a well-known forensic genealogist in California, who works with police agencies internationally on unidentified remains, made contact directly. As of Boland's 2021 follow-up, nothing had come of it (Boland, 2021) **(T1)**.

In Germany, the Bundeskriminalamt in Wiesbaden lists him among its unidentified dead, and issued appeals based on the C&A clothing and the Bayer aspirin (German-language case summaries; no citable source — see Appendix D) **(T3)**.

The identity

The Gardaí have Bergmann's DNA. They've had it since the initial encounter all those years ago. To this day, his clothes are still in the possession of the Gardaí (Garcia, 2019) **(T1)**.

Boland asked them the obvious question: why not upload the profile to a consumer genealogy database, the way cold cases elsewhere are now routinely solved? The answer she was given was that An Garda Síochána does not send DNA to Ancestry or comparable sites, and that while such a search might indicate region of origin, it would ultimately fail to identify him (Boland, 2021) **(T1)**.

That position — that regional ancestry is not identification — is the reason this case still remains dormant.

Ireland now maintains a national DNA database, established under the Criminal Justice (Forensic Evidence and DNA Database System) Act 2014 and operational from November 2015, holding profiles from more than 366 families and 43 sets of unidentified human remains, with 72 family profiles lodged on Interpol's I-Familia system. Bergmann's case was added to the human-remains database when it was unveiled in May 2023. Ireland has also established it will exhume remains for DNA when it decides to. In November 2024 the remains known as "Bandon Man" were exhumed, profiled, and the result sent to Interpol. It produced no match — but it could be done and was (Murphy, 2025) **(T1)**.

VI. THE GRAVE

By September 2009 nobody had come forward. No family, no employer, no consulate, no name.

On Friday 18 September 2009, the man who called himself Peter Bergmann was buried in Sligo Cemetery in an unmarked plot the Health Service Executive had purchased for the unclaimed dead. Six people were present (Boland, 2019b) **(T1)**.

Brian Scanlon dug the grave. He had worked at the cemetery for thirty years by then, and he spoke about the burial flatly — six mourners or six hundred, it's still a box that comes through the gate, then into the ground **(T3 — paraphrased; the Scanlon quotations circulate widely in secondary retellings and should be verified against Boland, 2019b, before use)**.

The plot could hold three burials. One other unidentified person was already in it. Bergmann made two.

Scanlon was given a specific instruction: no third body was to be added.

The reason was simple, they may need to dig him up (Boland, 2019b) **(T1)**.

VII. AFTERLIFE

Ironically, a man who spent the last days of his life systematically erasing every trace of himself is now known by more people than ever knew him alive.

The documentary

In 2013 the Irish filmmaker Ciaran Cassidy released *The Last Days of Peter Bergmann*, an eighteen-minute documentary produced by Morgan Bushe for Fastnet Films, edited by John Murphy, shot by Kate McCullough, with music by David Cantan and Jack Quilligan. It was funded through Bord Scannán na hÉireann / the Irish Film Board's "Reality Bites" scheme (Cassidy, 2013; IMDb, n.d.; Points North Institute, n.d.; Short of the Week, 2015) **(T2)**.

Cassidy first encountered the case at the Coroner's Court. He deliberately waited about a year — until it had gone cold — before approaching the investigating Garda, then worked through roughly thirty-two hours of CCTV (Points North Institute, n.d.; Short of the Week, 2015) **(T2)**.

It premiered at Sundance in 2014 and played more than fifty festivals, including Sheffield Doc/Fest and the Cork Film Festival. It won an IFTA for Best Short Film, Best Documentary Short at the Melbourne International Film Festival, a jury award at Nashville, the Audience Award at IFI Stranger Than Fiction, and special jury recognition at Milwaukee (IMDb, n.d.; Letterboxd, n.d.; Short of the Week, 2015) **(T2)**.

The Melbourne jury's citation contains the single best articulation of what this story actually is. They praised Cassidy for inverting the mystery genre — from whodunnit to why (Short of the Week, 2015) **(T2)**.

Cassidy has said the people of Sligo were willing to talk because they wanted the man found and returned to his family — because whatever he had planned had not, in the end, quite worked out (Short of the Week, 2015) **(T2)**.

The performances

A Dream of Dying, by Treasa Nealon — a one-man play that tells the story in reverse, imagining backwards from the beach toward a life. Nealon found the case by searching for unidentified missing people on Ireland's west coast, and has said the intention was to honour his memory. It played the Edinburgh Festival Fringe in 2016 (Fake Escape Theatre, performed by Lawrence Boothman) and toured in Ireland in 2018 (performed by Killian Glynn) (FringeReview, n.d.; Garcia, 2019; The Wee Review, n.d.) **(T1/T2)**.

Mr. Bergmann of Deadman's Point, by Nth Degree Productions — a dark comedy, around sixty-five minutes, in which Bergmann, mid-erasure, encounters an embalmer racing to secure his own legacy. It debuted at the Galway Theatre Festival in May 2025 at the Town Hall Theatre Studio, and was subsequently staged at the Civic Theatre in Tallaght in April 2026 and the dlr Mill Theatre in Dundrum in May 2026. It received a four-star review in the *Galway Advertiser* (Connacht Tribune, n.d.; dlr Mill Theatre, 2026; *Galway Advertiser*, 2025; Sunday World, n.d.; Town Hall Theatre Galway, 2025) **(T2)**.

ppl b making plays abt anything nowadays i stg bro.

The podcast

The Irish Times published *Atlantic*, Rosita Boland's three-part narrative podcast, in 2019. The episodes are titled "Land of Heart's Desire," "The Golden Man," and "The Black Notice" (Boland, 2019a) **(T1)**. The third title refers to the Interpol notice category — spot on, given Guintard's finding.

The appeals

The last formal An Garda Síochána public appeal was issued in October 2021 (An Garda Síochána, 2021; "Renewed appeal to identify body," 2021) **(T1)**.

In August 2023 — not 2026, a date that circulates widely and is wrong — the UK cold-case charity Locate International launched a renewed public appeal, reframing him as "Sligo Man." It included a new forensic depiction by the imaging consultant Hew Morrison, a video featuring CCTV footage, and an interactive presentation built with ThingLink. It posed seven specific public questions: whether the false address means anything to anyone; whether anyone received a letter posted from Sligo in June 2009; whether a dentist fitted a gold tooth; whether a doctor treated that cancer; whether anyone from Germany or Austria has a connection to Sligo, Derry or the west coast; whether anyone disappeared who matches his description; and whether anyone recognises the Tommy Hilfiger jumper, the C&A jacket or the Finn Comfort shoes (IrishCentral, n.d.-b; Locate International, 2023; "Peter Bergmann: Renewed appeal," 2023) **(T1/T2)**.

Locate International’s appeal was simply an awareness campaign run by volunteers. It presented no new forensic evidence.

The internet

In March 2025 the case went viral. The Swiss outlet Blick reported that a post from a small account with around ten thousand followers had reached over seventeen million views in a single day (Hillig, 2025) **(T2)**. LADbible covered further social-media resurfacing in March and again in July 2025, driven by TikTok (LADbible, 2025) **(T2)**. In August 2026, Boing Boing published a retelling (Boing Boing, 2026) **(T2)**.

Online, the theories sort into four:

1. *A terminally ill man who travelled somewhere quiet to die anonymously.* This is the interpretation the evidence best supports, and broadly the one both O'Reilly and Mulderrig arrived at: the cancer he must have been diagnosed with, the systematic destruction of identifying material, the single bus ticket, the beach at high tide, the folded clothes.
2. *An intelligence officer, or someone with military or police training.* This rests almost entirely on MacMahon's observation about camera evasion. There is no corroborating evidence for it.
3. *Someone fleeing criminal, financial or insurance trouble.* Popular online — Garcia counted nine Reddit threads by 2019 — with no evidentiary basis at all (Garcia, 2019) **(T1)**.

4. *A hoax staged by the filmmaker.* This one should be addressed and dismissed on screen, because it circulates. Garcia put it to Cassidy directly. Cassidy replied that it was real, and welcomed him to the rabbit hole (Garcia, 2019) **(T1)**. The autopsy, the inquest, the Garda file and sixteen independent witnesses settle it.

Of the enormous volume of amateur investigation — Reddit, Websleuths, the Doe Network, a German forum thread running past a hundred and sixty pages — only two things of substance have emerged. One is forensic art. The other was a tip from a German user who thought the man resembled someone he had done East German national service with, from Altwarp in Mecklenburg-Vorpommern. It was reportedly followed up; the named man was found to be alive **(T3 — sourced to German-language forums and podcasts of variable reliability; treat as indicative only)**.

Everything else is noise.

VIII. SLIGO MAN

Seventeen years on, we should stop calling him Peter Bergmann. It was never his name. It was the last thing he built, and he built it well enough that it has outlived everyone's ability to see past it.

In Adelaide, in 1948, a man was found dead on Somerton Beach with the labels cut out of his clothes. For seventy-four years he was Australia's most famous unidentified body. Then, on 26 July 2022, Professor Derek Abbott of the University of Adelaide and the American forensic genealogist Colleen Fitzpatrick announced they had identified him: Carl "Charles" Webb, an electrical engineer and instrument maker, born in Melbourne in 1905, forty-three years old at death ("Somerton man mystery," 2022) **(T1)**.

They did it by extracting DNA from hairs embedded in the plaster death mask made of him in 1948, uploading the profile to consumer genealogy databases, and building outward from distant cousins until they had a family tree of roughly four thousand people. The body had been exhumed the previous May ("Somerton Man," n.d.; "Somerton man mystery," 2022) **(T1/T2)**.

Sligo Man should be an easier problem than that. His body is not seventy-four years old, only seventeen. It was recovered fresh, and autopsied within a day. His DNA is not trapped in plaster — it was taken properly, in 2009, and An Garda Síochána still holds it. His grave is known, its location is recorded, and the man who dug it was told to leave the third space empty for the purpose of future exhumation.

As opposed to the technical obstacles that Somerton Man presented, this case has none.

What it has instead is a policy: that uploading a profile to a genealogy database might tell you where a man came from, but would not tell you who he was (Boland, 2021) **(T1)**. That was a defensible position in 2009. It became harder to defend in 2018, when the same method began closing decades-old cases across the United States. It became harder still in 2022, when it produced a name for a body that had been in the ground since before the Berlin Wall was erected.

He is buried under a plot number in Sligo. But somewhere — in Germany, Austria, somewhere his shoes and his coat and his aspirin and his accent all belong — there is a dentist who fitted a gold tooth into the upper right of a man's jaw. There is an oncologist who told a patient how long he had to live. Somewhere there is a letter, postmarked Sligo, June 2009.

He went to extraordinary lengths to make sure no one would ever find him. He cut the labels out of his clothes. He emptied a bag thirteen times in a town full of cameras without once being seen doing it. He bought a single ticket.

He very nearly succeeded. Nearly — because sixteen people saw him on that beach and remembered him well enough to describe him, a father and son found him at dawn, a pathologist read his body carefully enough to tell us he was dying, and a gravedigger was told to leave a space.

The final question is not who he was. He asked, as emphatically as a person can, never to be identified. We have the means to identify him anyway. Seventeen years later, with the right tools sitting unused and

a grave deliberately left open, perhaps the question we should be asking is whose wish we are actually honouring?

APPENDICES

APPENDIX A — RECONCILED TIMELINE

Date / time	Event
Fri 12 Jun 2009, c.2:30–4:00 p.m.	On CCTV, Ulsterbus depot, Foyle Street, Derry
4:00 p.m.	Boards Sligo bus (2 hr 28 min journey)
6:28 p.m.	Alights Sligo, carrying black duffel + black shoulder bag
—	Taxi to Crúiscín Lán guest house, Connolly Street — full
6:52 p.m.	Enters Sligo City Hotel, Quay Street (CCTV)
—	Checks in as "Peter Bergmann," Ainstettersn 15, 4472 Wien; cash, €65/night × 3; room 705; no ID requested
Sat 13 Jun, c.10:49 a.m.	Sligo General Post Office — buys 82c stamps + airmail stickers
across 12–15 Jun	Leaves hotel 13 times with full purple bag; returns empty each time; never filmed disposing
Sun 14 Jun, c.11:00–11:30 a.m.	Taxi (Gerard Higgins) toward Rosses Point; does not exit; returns to bus station; pays with new €20
Mon 15 Jun, c.1:05 p.m.	Checks out (late checkout granted to 1 p.m.)
—	Walks Quay St → Wine St; pauses in Quayside Shopping Centre doorway
1:32 p.m.	CCTV, bus station — black duffel now gone
—	Café: cappuccino + toasted ham & cheese sandwich; sits beside a woman, no conversation; reads/writes on scraps, tears up, bins them
—	Asks Vincent Dunbar re: Rosses Point bay; buys single ticket
2:20 / 2:40 p.m.	Bus departs (see Appendix D)
c.3:00 p.m.	Arrives at Yeats Country Hotel stop
4:00 p.m.	Sighted, black bag over shoulder
5:00 p.m.	Sighted near yacht club
9:10 p.m.	Sighted by two women
9:30 p.m.	Sighted by Dermot & Paula Lahiff — slow shore walk, trousers rolled, right to left
10:30 p.m.	Sighted with plastic bag, wearing glasses

11:00 p.m.	Sighted
11:10 p.m.	Sighted sitting on a bench
11:50 p.m.	Final sighting — plastic bag, at water's edge
Tue 16 Jun, c.12:25 a.m.	High tide
c.6:00–6:45 a.m.	Body found by Arthur & Brian Kinsella, near slipway / Deadman's Point
8:00 a.m.	Death pronounced (Dr Valerie McGowan)
Wed 17 Jun	Post-mortem, Sligo University Hospital (Dr Clive Kilgallen)
Fri 18 Sep 2009	Burial, Sligo Cemetery, unmarked HSE plot; six present
14 Apr 2010	Inquest

APPENDIX B — FULL INVENTORY OF RECOVERED ITEMS

Worn on the body

- Navy T-shirt (tucked in)
- Navy underpants (worn over the trunks)
- Pink/purple striped Speedo-type swimming trunks
- Waterproof quartz watch, left wrist

Folded on the rocks

- Black leather Finn Comfort shoes, size 44 — manufactured Germany, 2002
- Dark socks
- Black leather C&A jacket
- Navy C&A chino trousers
- Black sleeveless Tommy Hilfiger jumper
- Black leather belt, "Key West USA," made in Italy

All clothing labels cut out.

In pockets

- Envelope containing one hundred forty euros in notes and nine euros in coins
- Tissues
- Bayer aspirin — manufactured Czech Republic, distributed Germany
- Hansaplast plasters
- Unopened bar of soap, "Mild Soap, Hotel Care" — stocked by no Irish hotel
- Blank identification cards (reported in Murphy, 2025 — verify)

Never recovered

- His glasses
- The stamps
- The pale blue shirt
- The black duffel
- The black shoulder bag
- The purple plastic bag and everything in it
- Any form of identification

APPENDIX C — CAST OF NAMED WITNESSES AND OFFICIALS

Name	Role
Arthur Kinsella	Found the body, 16 June 2009, with his son
Brian Kinsella	Son; was training for a triathlon that morning
Sgt Terry MacMahon	First Garda at scene; brought the tarp; raised the "training" observation
Dr Valerie McGowan	Pronounced death at 8:00 a.m.
Dr Clive Kilgallen	Consultant pathologist, Sligo University Hospital; post-mortem, 17 June 2009
Gerard Higgins	Taxi driver, Sunday 14 June; recalled the gold tooth
Vincent Dunbar	Sligo bus depot inspector; described him as stressed or in pain
Dermot & Paula Lahiff	Couple who watched him walk the shore at c.9:30 p.m.
DI / Chief Supt John O'Reilly	Oversaw the investigation in 2009; later Chief Supt, Cavan-Monaghan
DI Ray Mulderrig	Held the file by 2019; third DI on the case
Brian Scanlon	Sligo Cemetery caretaker; dug the grave; instructed to leave the third space
Rosita Boland	*Irish Times* senior features writer; the definitive reporting
Francisco Garcia	*Vice*; 2019 reported feature
Julien Guintard	*Le Monde*; established the Austrian/Interpol failure
Ciaran Cassidy	Director, *The Last Days of Peter Bergmann* (2013)
Treasa Nealon	Playwright, *A Dream of Dying*
Hew Morrison	Forensic imaging consultant; 2023 depiction for Locate International

APPENDIX D — A NOTE ON THE RECORD

Six points where the public record genuinely conflicts. Use either the conservative version or acknowledge the conflict.

1. Eight stamps or ten? Boland, quoting the Garda file, says ten eighty-two cent stamps; Locate International's timeline also says ten. Vice, the 2023 press appeals, most Irish outlets and the German coverage say eight. The Boland (2019b) / Garda-file figure is the most authoritative; "eight" is the most widely repeated.

2. Did he actually post anything? Best-sourced answer: it was never established that he posted anything at all. The post-office interior CCTV failed to save; the exterior boxes had no cameras. Garcia's (2019) phrasing — that the letters he posted were never traced — overstates the certainty. Use the Boland (2019b) version.

3. "Thirteen times" or "each morning"? Thirteen is the precise figure, sourced to O'Reilly via Boland (2019b). "Each morning for three days" is a loose paraphrase in secondary retellings.

4. Bus departure — 2:20 p.m. or 2:40 p.m.? Garcia (2019) gives 2:20; Boland (2019b) and the German sources give 2:40. Unresolved.

5. Drowning or cardiac arrest? The post-mortem found no classical drowning and gave acute cardiac arrest as cause of death. The inquest of 14 April 2010 recorded a verdict of death by drowning (Murphy, 2025). This is a real discrepancy between the pathologist's finding and the coroner's recorded verdict.

6. Which detective led it? Both O'Reilly and Mulderrig are correct, at different times. O'Reilly in 2009; Mulderrig by 2019, as the third DI. MacMahon was the responding sergeant, not an investigator.

Additional flags:

- The *"August 2026 Locate International appeal" does not exist.* Locate's "Sligo Man" appeal is August 2023. What happened in 2025–26 was viral internet attention, not investigative development. This error circulates.
- *No forensic genetic genealogy, isotope analysis or exhumation has ever been performed on this case.* Content claiming otherwise — including claims that "DNA was run against every database" or that facial recognition was used — is fabricated. Several AI-generated true-crime pages assert this.
- The *Scanlon graveside quotations* and the breakdown of the six mourners circulate mainly in secondary retellings.
- The *"Why Sligo?" quotation attributed to Mulderrig* appears mainly in low-tier aggregators. The sentiment is well supported; the exact wording is not. Paraphrase, or verify.
- *Two in-text attributions have no citable source* and are carried in the text as unsourced: the "Unidentified-persons summaries" reference in Section IV (now removed — the claim rests on Boland, 2019b) and "German-language case summaries" in Section V. The latter needs a specific BKA page or named German article before it can appear in an APA reference list.

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Tier 3 — Flagged. Used only to document the amateur-investigation ecosystem, never as fact

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